

Tourism and Regional Economic Development in Custer County

Custer Area Economic Development Foundation | Coyote Business Consulting | April 2026

This brief summarizes a client-facing consulting project completed for the Custer Area Economic Development Foundation. The project used publicly available economic, labor, tourism, lodging, and taxable-sales indicators to assess the role of tourism in Custer County, South Dakota and translate evidence into planning-oriented findings for local stakeholders.

Selected Findings

Indicator	Portfolio takeaway
Tourism employment	Tourism-related activity supported 24.3% of county employment in 2022.
Jobs supported	751 direct jobs and 1,160 total supported jobs.
Labor income	About \$21.2 million in direct labor income and \$38.8 million in total labor income.
Tax receipts	About \$9.2 million in state and local tax receipts.
Taxable-sales concentration	Custer City generated 87.7% of county taxable sales.
Custer State Park	Estimated \$83.7 million economic contribution.

Methods and Data

- Combined public tourism-impact estimates, taxable-sales data, labor-market information, lodging capacity indicators, and regional benchmark comparisons.
- Compared countywide patterns with city-level indicators to distinguish broad county trends from the commercial role of Custer City.
- Interpreted Custer State Park metrics as major tourism-asset indicators rather than treating any single source as a complete causal estimate.
- Focused on actionable economic development interpretation rather than a highly technical academic model.

Client-Oriented Recommendations

- Use seasonal tourism patterns more intentionally in planning, budgeting, communication, and stakeholder outreach.
- Continue peer-county benchmarking to place Custer County’s tourism dependency and business structure in regional context.
- Use Custer State Park and taxable-sales indicators to communicate the local importance of tourism to stakeholders.
- Treat Custer City as a central commercial hub whose retail, services, and lodging activity reflect broader county tourism dynamics.

Role and Portfolio Relevance

This was a team consulting project. My strongest contributions were in later-stage interpretation, report writing, presentation preparation, and communication of findings for a nontechnical audience. The project demonstrates applied public-data analysis, client-facing economic development work, and translation of quantitative evidence into practical recommendations.

Visual Summary

Tourism and Regional Economic Development

Custer County, South Dakota | Client-facing economic development consulting project

Tourism employment

24.3%

of county employment

Jobs supported

1,160

total jobs; 751 direct

Labor income

\$38.8M

total labor income

Tax receipts

\$9.2M

state and local taxes

Major Patterns

- **Seasonality**
Tourism activity peaks in summer and early fall.
- **Sales concentration**
Custer City accounts for 87.7% of county taxable sales.
- **Anchor asset**
Custer State Park is central to visitor activity and lodging demand.

Business mix

Retail and services make up about 85% of Custer City taxable sales.

Client-Relevant Takeaways

- **Planning**
Use seasonal patterns in budgeting, staffing, and communication.
- **Benchmarking**
Use peer-county comparisons to contextualize county performance.
- **Messaging**
Use Custer State Park and taxable-sales indicators in stakeholder communication.

Economic development signal

Tourism is a core driver of local employment, public revenue, and stakeholder planning.

Portfolio summary graphic from public economic, tourism, labor, taxable-sales, and lodging indicators.

The summary graphic highlights the core client-facing message: tourism is not only a visitor activity in Custer County; it is a major component of employment, labor income, taxable sales, and public revenue.